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# Attack on Parliament and Operation Parakram

On 13 December 2001, we were aghast as the Indian Parliament came under a terrorist attack. Five terrorists on a suicidal mission (later learnt to be from Lashkar-e-Toiba and Jaish-e-Mohammad) had managed to enter the precincts of the Parliament House. The Parliament was in session though it had been adjourned some time before the attack. The terrorists were heavily armed and tried to rush into the main building while firing indiscriminately. However, due to effective action taken by the paramilitary forces on guard duty and some fortuitous circumstances, none of the terrorists could gain entry into the main hall, where many political leaders and parliamentarians were deliberating on the proceedings of the day. The exchange of fire took place for a few hours, by which time the site of the encounter was sealed and the army was placed on standby. Eventually, all the five terrorists were killed, though in the shootout seven paramilitary personnel also lost their lives. No member of Parliament or minister was hurt. All nations of the world condemned this brazen act of terrorism, including Pakistan (*sic*). On the other hand, the statement of the Pakistani military spokesman, Major General Rashid Qureshi, that, 'this attack was a drama staged by Indian intelligence agencies to defame the freedom struggle in occupied Kashmir,' was ridiculous and horribly repugnant.

In a matter of a few days, we received orders to mobilize for war and move to our designated areas for Operation Parakram. By early January, my corps was ready. Pakistan responded similarly, but took more time as it had to move back troops from its borders on